# 외계행성 대기
# Exoplanetary Atmospheres

## Lecture 10: Atmospheric Opacities and Scattering

2026 November 16 (Monday)

**Based on: Chapter 8 of Seager, *Exoplanet Atmospheres* (2010), and Chapter 5 of Heng, *Exoplanetary Atmospheres: Theoretical Concepts and Foundations* (2017)**

선광일 (Kwangil Seon)
KASI / UST

2026-11-10 23:57

# Outline – Lecture 10

Molecular Transitions and Line Lists

Spectral Line Broadening and the $k$-Distribution Method

Rayleigh Scattering by Gas Molecules

Cloud and Condensate Opacities

Continuum Opacities

Summary

# Normal Modes of Polyatomic Molecules

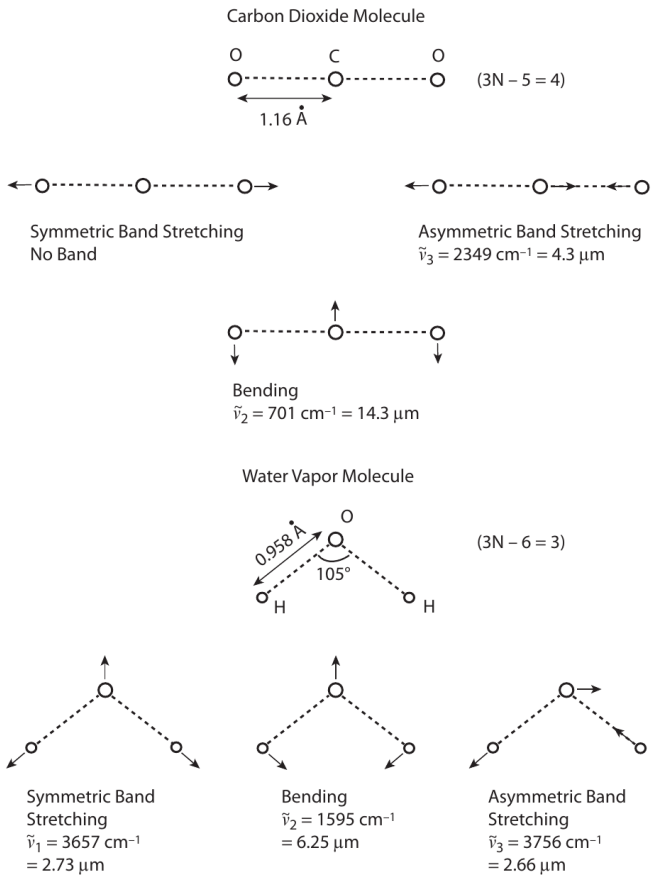



Figure 1: Fundamental normal modes of linear $CO_2$ ($3N-5=4$ modes; $\nu_2$ is doubly degenerate) and bent $H_2O$ ($3N-6=3$ modes). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.8.

- **Counting normal modes of an $N$-atom molecule:** Subtracting 3 translational and 2 (linear) or 3 (nonlinear) rotational degrees of freedom from the $3N$ total degrees of freedom leaves the number of independent fundamental vibrational **normal modes**:

$$N_{\text{vib}} = \begin{cases} 3N-5 & \text{(linear, e.g. } CO_2\text{: 4 modes)}, \\ 3N-6 & \text{(nonlinear, e.g. } H_2O\text{: 3; } CH_4\text{: 9)}. \end{cases}$$

- **Key greenhouse molecules:**
  - **$CO_2$ (linear):** symmetric stretch $\nu_1$ (1388 cm$^{-1}$, **IR-inactive** because bond dipoles cancel); doubly degenerate bending mode $\nu_2$ (667 cm$^{-1}$, $\lambda = 15\,\mu$m, dominant greenhouse band on Earth, Venus, Mars); asymmetric stretch $\nu_3$ (2349 cm$^{-1}$, $\lambda = 4.3\,\mu$m).
  - **$H_2O$ (bent,** 104.5°**):** symmetric stretch $\nu_1$ (2.73 $\mu$m), bending mode $\nu_2$ (6.27 $\mu$m), and asymmetric stretch $\nu_3$ (2.66 $\mu$m), all strongly IR-active.

# Molecular Electronic Transitions and Photodissociation

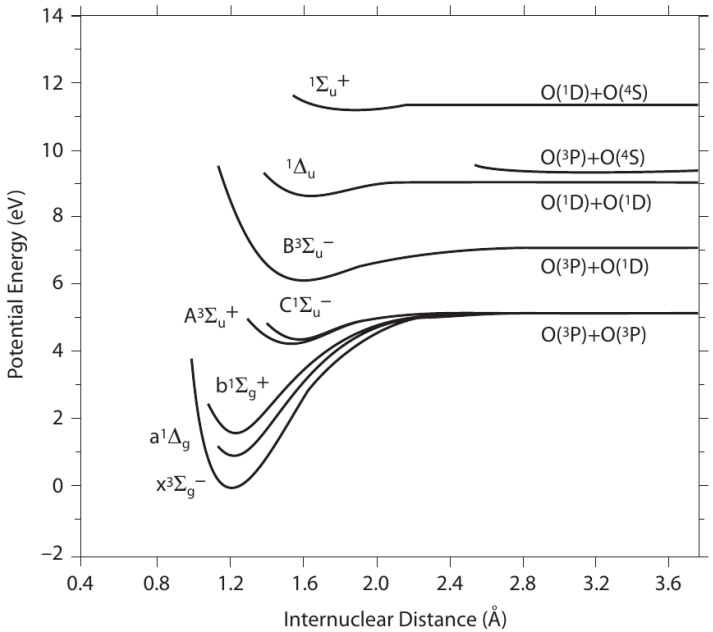



Figure 2: Potential energy curves $E(r)$ for electronic states of $O_2$, illustrating anharmonic vibrational levels and dissociation limits. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.9.

- **Potential energy curves $E(r)$ of electronic states:** Each electronic configuration of a molecule has its own potential curve $E(r)$ supporting a ladder of anharmonic vibrational ($v$) and rotational ($J$) sublevels, so an electronic transition produces an entire system of ro-vibrational bands in the **UV and visible** ($\Delta E_{\rm el} \sim$ few eV).
- **Bound-bound electronic bands in hot exoplanets:**
  - At $T \lesssim 500$ K, molecules reside in their ground electronic state and electronic bands lie in the UV (e.g. $O_2$, $O_3$).
  - In hot Jupiters and brown dwarfs ($T \sim 1500$–$3000$ K), **TiO**, **VO**, FeH, and CrH have low-lying electronic states with strong optical absorption bands that heat the upper atmosphere and drive **thermal inversions**.
- **Photodissociation (bound-free continuum):** UV photons that excite a molecule above the dissociation limit of an upper potential curve break the bond into free atoms (e.g. $O_2 + h\nu \rightarrow O + O$), producing continuous UV opacity.

# Energy Level Populations: LTE vs. Non-LTE Statistical Equilibrium

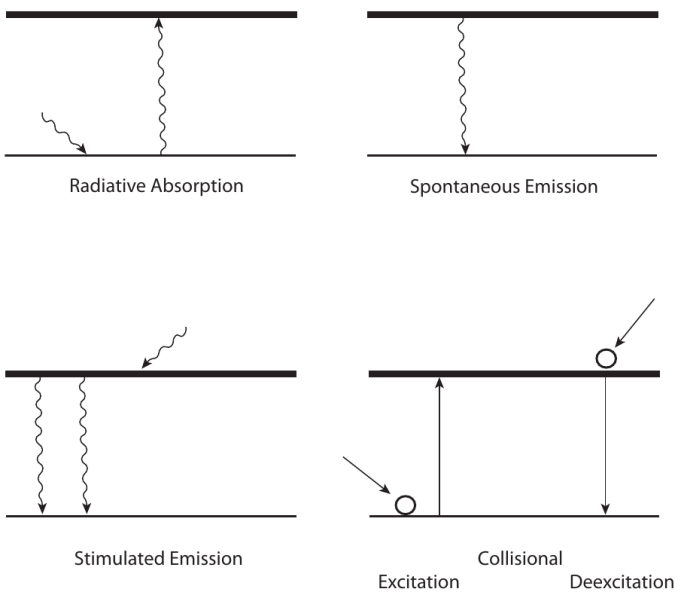



Figure 3: Radiative ($A_{ul}$, $B_{ul}J_{\bar{\nu}}$, $B_{lu}J_{\bar{\nu}}$) and collisional ($C_{lu}$,$C_{ul}$) transitions in a two-level system. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.10.

- **LTE populations — Boltzmann distribution:** Where molecular collisions dominate over radiative decay (e.g. $z \lesssim 60$–$70$ km on Earth), level populations follow the **Boltzmann distribution** at local kinetic temperature $T$:

$$\boxed{\frac{n_j}{n} = \frac{g_j\,\mathrm{e}^{-E_j/k_\mathrm{B}T}}{Q(T)}, \qquad Q(T) \equiv \sum_i g_i\,\mathrm{e}^{-E_i/k_\mathrm{B}T}}$$

$$\frac{n_J}{n_0} = (2J+1)\,\mathrm{e}^{-BJ(J+1)/k_\mathrm{B}T}, \qquad \frac{n_\upsilon}{n_0} = \mathrm{e}^{-\upsilon h\nu_0/k_\mathrm{B}T}.$$

- **Non-LTE statistical equilibrium:** At high altitudes / low pressures where collisions are rare, populations must be solved from **detailed balance** with the mean radiation field $J_{\bar{\nu}} = \int_0^\infty J_\nu \phi(\nu-\nu_0)\,\mathrm{d}\nu$ via the **Einstein coefficients** $A_{ul}, B_{ul}, B_{lu}$:

$$\boxed{\begin{gathered} n_u A_{ul} - n_u B_{ul} J_{\bar{\nu}} = n_l B_{lu} J_{\bar{\nu}}, \\ B_{ul} = \frac{g_l}{g_u} B_{lu}, \qquad A_{ul} = \frac{2h\nu^3}{c^2}\frac{g_l}{g_u} B_{lu} \end{gathered}}$$

# Molecular Absorption Cross Section and Quantum Line Strength

The monochromatic absorption cross section $\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu})$ (cm$^2$ molecule$^{-1}$) for a transition between lower state $l$ and upper state $u$ centered at wavenumber $\tilde{\nu}_0$ factors into a temperature-dependent **line strength** $S_{lu}(T)$ and a normalized **line profile** $f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0)$:

$$\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu}) = S_{lu}(T)\, f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0), \qquad \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0)\,\mathrm{d}\tilde{\nu} = 1, \qquad S_{lu}(T) \equiv \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu})\,\mathrm{d}\tilde{\nu}$$

- **Quantum mechanical expression for line strength:** From the microscopic radiative transfer relation $\left[n_l B_{lu} - n_u B_{ul}\right] \frac{h\tilde{\nu}_0}{4\pi c} f(\tilde{\nu}-\tilde{\nu}_0) = n\,\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu})$ in LTE,

$$S_{lu}(T) = \frac{h\tilde{\nu}_0}{4\pi c}\frac{n_l}{n} B_{lu}\left(1 - \mathrm{e}^{-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_\mathrm{B}T}\right), \qquad B_{lu} = \frac{8\pi^3}{3h^2 c}\left|\int \Phi_u^* \boldsymbol{\mu}_e \Phi_l \,\mathrm{d}V\right|^2$$

  - The factor $\left(1 - \mathrm{e}^{-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_\mathrm{B}T}\right)$ corrects absorption for **stimulated emission** (which acts as negative absorption along the beam).
  - The dipole transition moment integral $\int \Phi_u^* \boldsymbol{\mu}_e \Phi_l \,\mathrm{d}V$ vanishes unless the wave functions have opposite parity, giving the **quantum selection rules** ($\Delta J = \pm 1$ or $0, \pm 1$; $\Delta v = \pm 1$).

# Spectroscopic Line Lists and Temperature Scaling of Line Strengths

- **Why empirical and ab initio spectroscopic databases are needed:**
  - Computing exact wave functions $\Phi_l, \Phi_u$, energy levels $E_i$, and dipole transition moments for polyatomic molecules across millions to billions of ro-vibrational transitions from first principles is extremely challenging.
  - Planetary atmosphere models therefore rely on laboratory measurements combined with quantum mechanical calculations compiled in databases such as **HITRAN** ($T_{\mathrm{ref}} = 296$ K), **HITEMP**, and **ExoMol** (for high-temperature exoplanets and brown dwarfs up to $T \sim 3000$ K).

- **Scaling tabulated line strengths $S_{lu}(T_{\mathrm{ref}})$ to atmospheric temperature $T$:** Using the Boltzmann relation $\dfrac{n_l(T)}{n} = \dfrac{g_l\, \mathrm{e}^{-E_l/k_{\mathrm{B}}T}}{Q(T)}$ in the expression for $S_{lu}(T)$, the unknown Einstein coefficient $B_{lu}$ cancels out in the ratio $S_{lu}(T)/S_{lu}(T_{\mathrm{ref}})$:

$$\boxed{S_{lu}(T) = S_{lu}(T_{\mathrm{ref}})\, \frac{Q(T_{\mathrm{ref}})}{Q(T)}\, \frac{\exp(-E_l/k_{\mathrm{B}}T)}{\exp(-E_l/k_{\mathrm{B}}T_{\mathrm{ref}})}\, \frac{1-\exp(-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_{\mathrm{B}}T)}{1-\exp(-hc\tilde{\nu}_0/k_{\mathrm{B}}T_{\mathrm{ref}})}}$$

  where $E_l$ is the lower-state energy, $Q(T)$ is the total internal partition function, and the last ratio accounts for the temperature dependence of stimulated emission.

# Spectral Line Broadening: Natural and Doppler Broadening

Spectral lines are never infinitely sharp $\delta(\nu - \nu_0)$ functions; quantum uncertainty, thermal motions, and intermolecular collisions broaden the line profile $f(\nu - \nu_0)$:

- **1. Natural (radiative) broadening:**
  - An excited state with finite radiative lifetime $\Delta t = 1/A_{ul}$ has an energy uncertainty $\Delta E\,\Delta t \sim h/(2\pi)$ (**Heisenberg uncertainty principle**), yielding a **Lorentz profile** with half-width at half-maximum (HWHM) $\gamma_N$:

$$f_N(\nu - \nu_0) = \frac{1}{\pi}\frac{\gamma_N}{(\nu - \nu_0)^2 + \gamma_N^2}, \qquad \gamma_N = \frac{1}{2\pi\Delta t} = \frac{A_{ul}}{2\pi}$$

(negligible in planetary atmospheres).

- **2. Thermal (Doppler) broadening:**
  - Thermal line-of-sight velocities $v_z$ follow a 1D Maxwell–Boltzmann distribution $\propto \exp[-mv_z^2/(2k_B T)]$, shifting transition frequencies to $\nu = \nu_0(1 \pm v_z/c)$ and producing a **Gaussian line profile**:

$$f_D(\nu - \nu_0) = \frac{1}{\gamma_D\sqrt{\pi}}\exp\left[-\left(\frac{\nu - \nu_0}{\gamma_D}\right)^2\right],$$

$$\gamma_D \equiv \frac{\nu_0}{c}\sqrt{\frac{2k_B T}{m}}, \qquad \mathrm{FWHM}_D = 2\sqrt{\ln 2}\,\gamma_D$$

  - Because $\exp(-x^2)$ drops off rapidly away from $\nu_0$, Doppler broadening dominates near the **line core** and at **low pressures (upper atmosphere)**.

# Spectral Line Broadening: Pressure Broadening and the Voigt Profile

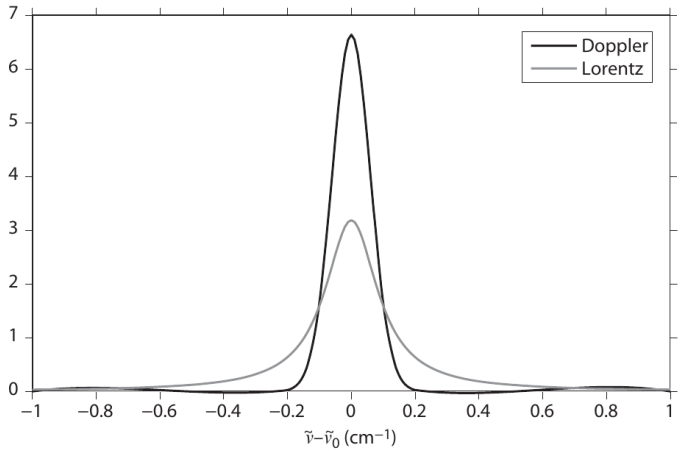



Figure 4: Comparison of a Gaussian Doppler profile and a Lorentzian pressure-broadened profile of equal area and width: the Gaussian is more peaked at line center, whereas the Lorentzian has much broader wings. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.11.

- **3. Collisional (pressure) broadening:** Collisions randomly interrupt the phase of the radiating wave train on mean collision time $\Delta t_{\rm coll}$, yielding a **Lorentz profile** with HWHM $\gamma_{\rm L}$:

$$\boxed{f_{\rm L}(\nu-\nu_0)=\frac{1}{\pi}\frac{\gamma_{\rm L}}{(\nu-\nu_0)^2+\gamma_{\rm L}^2}, \qquad \gamma_{\rm L}=\gamma_{\rm L,0}\left(\frac{P}{P_0}\right)\left(\frac{T_0}{T}\right)^{n_T}}$$

  ($n_T=0.5$ in kinetic theory; $n_T\approx 0.4$–$0.75$ empirically). Because $(\nu-\nu_0)^{-2}$ decays slowly, Lorentz wings dominate the **line wings** and at **high pressures** ($P \gtrsim 0.1$ **bar**).

- **4. Combined Voigt profile:** Convolution of the Gaussian and Lorentzian profiles:

$$\boxed{f_{\rm V}(\nu-\nu_0)=\frac{1}{\gamma_{\rm D}\sqrt{\pi}}K(x,y)}$$

  where the **Voigt function** is

$$K(x,y)=\frac{y}{\pi}\int_{-\infty}^{\infty}\frac{{\rm e}^{-t^2}}{y^2+(x-t)^2}\,{\rm d}t$$

  with dimensionless variables $x\equiv\frac{\nu-\nu_0}{\gamma_{\rm D}}$ and $y\equiv\frac{\gamma_{\rm L}}{\gamma_{\rm D}}$.

# Line-by-Line Opacity Calculations and Spectral Challenges

- **The computational challenge of line-by-line (LBL) radiative transfer:**
  - In hot planetary atmospheres ($T \sim 1000$–$3000$ K), high thermal excitation populates thousands of vibrational levels. Databases like **HITEMP** and **ExoMol** contain **hundreds of millions to billions of transitions** for $H_2O$, $CO_2$, $CH_4$, CO, TiO, and VO.
  - Resolving the narrow Doppler core and Voigt profile of every individual line requires an ultra-fine wavenumber grid:

$$\Delta\tilde{\nu} \lesssim 10^{-3}\text{–}10^{-2}\ \text{cm}^{-1} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \sim 10^{6}\text{–}10^{7}\ \text{spectral grid points per spectrum.}$$

  - Direct LBL integration in iterative radiative–convective solvers (requiring hundreds of flux evaluations) or Bayesian MCMC retrievals ($10^5$ forward models) is computationally prohibitive.

- **Line wing cutoff in the far wings:**
  - The standard Lorentzian profile $f_L \propto (\nu - \nu_0)^{-2}$ is derived from the **impact approximation** (assuming collisions are instantaneous and elastic).
  - In the far wings ($|\tilde{\nu} - \tilde{\nu}_0| \gtrsim 25$–$100\ \text{cm}^{-1}$ for molecules; several thousand $\text{cm}^{-1}$ for $H_2$-broadened Na and K resonance lines in hot Jupiters), finite collision duration and interatomic forces cause absorption to drop off exponentially below the Lorentzian prediction (**sub-Lorentzian behavior**), requiring an empirical or quantum wing cutoff ($\chi$-factor).

- **Need for band models and distribution methods:** To accelerate radiative transfer by factors of $10^4$–$10^5$ without sacrificing the precision of quantum line lists, planetary atmosphere models rely on the ***k*-distribution method**.

# The $k$-Distribution Method: Reordering in Frequency Space

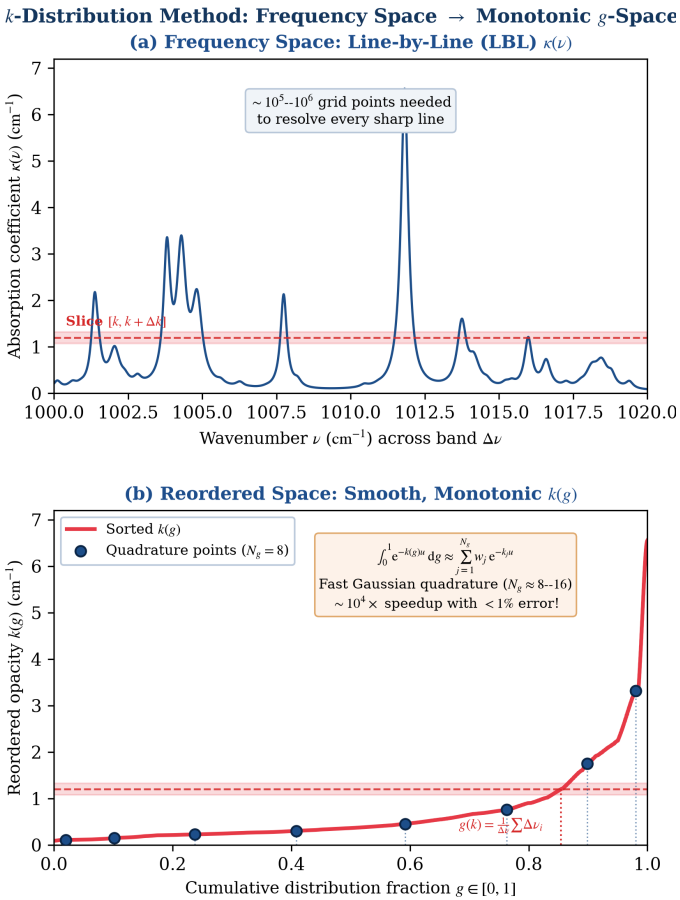



Figure 5: Transformation from oscillating $\kappa(\nu)$ across band $\Delta\nu = 1020 - 1000 = 20\ \mathrm{cm}^{-1}$ to smooth, monotonic $k(g)$.

- **Definitions of key symbols:**
  - $\boldsymbol{\kappa(\nu)}$: Monochromatic absorption coefficient ($\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$) oscillating with $\nu$.
  - $\boldsymbol{u}$: Absorber column density (cm or $\mathrm{g\,cm}^{-2}$; optical depth $\tau = \kappa u$).
  - $\boldsymbol{k}$: Opacity value variable; $\boldsymbol{f(k)}$: probability density of opacity.
  - $\boldsymbol{g(k)} \in [0,1]$: Cumulative fraction of band $\Delta\nu$ where $\kappa(\nu) \le k$: $g(k) \equiv \int_0^k f(k')\,\mathrm{d}k' = \frac{1}{\Delta\nu}\sum_i \Delta\nu_i$. $f(k) = \mathrm{d}g/\mathrm{d}k$.
  - $\boldsymbol{k(g)}$: Reordered, smooth monotonic opacity curve (inverse of $g(k)$).
  - $\boldsymbol{g_j, w_j}$: Gauss–Legendre quadrature evaluation nodes and weights.
- **Frequency invariance of band transmission:**

$$\bar{\mathscr{T}}_{\Delta\nu}(u) = \frac{1}{\Delta\nu}\int_{\Delta\nu} \mathrm{e}^{-\kappa(\nu)u}\,\mathrm{d}\nu = \int_0^\infty f(k)\,\mathrm{e}^{-ku}\,\mathrm{d}k = \int_0^1 \mathrm{e}^{-ku}\,\mathrm{d}g$$

- **Fast Gaussian quadrature ($N_g \approx 8$–$16$, $\sim 10^4\times$ speedup):**

$$\bar{\mathscr{T}}_{\Delta\nu}(u) = \int_0^1 \mathrm{e}^{-k(g)u}\,\mathrm{d}g \approx \sum_{j=1}^{Ng} w_j\,\mathrm{e}^{-k(g_j)u}$$

# The Correlated-$k$ Method in Inhomogeneous Atmospheres

- **Inhomogeneous vertical paths ($T(z)$, $P(z)$):**
  - In planetary atmospheres, $T$ and $P$ vary continuously with altitude $z$, so optical depth across a layer is $\tau(\nu) = \int \kappa(\nu, T(z), P(z))\, \rho(z)\, \mathrm{d}z$.
  - Because line shapes change with altitude, a simple layer-by-layer $k$-distribution cannot be directly multiplied unless line rank ordering is preserved.
- **The correlated-$k$ approximation (Lacis & Oinas 1991):**
  - We assume the rank ordering of $\kappa(\nu)$ in frequency space is **strongly correlated** across all atmospheric layers:

$$g\left(\nu, z_1\right) \approx g\left(\nu, z_2\right).$$

  - That is, a wavenumber with high absorption at pressure $P_1$ also has high absorption at pressure $P_2$.
  - This permits calculating optical depth **independently for each $g$-quadrature point**:

$$\tau(g_j) = \int_{z_{\mathrm{bot}}}^{z_{\mathrm{top}}} k\left(g_j, T(z), P(z)\right) \rho(z)\, \mathrm{d}z, \qquad \bar{\mathscr{T}}_{\Delta\nu} \approx \sum_{j=1}^{N_g} w_j\, \mathrm{e}^{-\tau(g_j)}$$

  - The radiative transfer equation is solved once per $g_j$ as a set of standard **pseudo-monochromatic** calculations!

# Correlated-$k$ for Gas Mixtures and Atmospheric Modeling

- **Treating gas mixtures ($H_2O + CO + CH_4 + \ldots$):**
  - **Random overlap approximation:** If absorption lines of different molecular species are statistically uncorrelated within $\Delta\nu$, total transmission is the product of individual transmissions:

$$\bar{\mathcal{T}}_{\text{mix}} \approx \prod_s \bar{\mathcal{T}}_s = \prod_s \left( \sum_{j=1}^{N_g} w_j \, \mathrm{e}^{-\tau_s(g_j)} \right).$$

  - **Pre-mixed $k$-distribution tables:** For self-consistent 1D/3D exoplanet climate models, opacities are pre-computed on chemical equilibrium grids $(T, P, [\text{Fe/H}], \text{C/O})$, combining all gases into a single composite $k(g)$.

- **Limitations and modern exoplanet applications:**
  - **Breakdown of correlation:** When lines within the same band have widely different lower-state energies $E_l$, their relative strengths change drastically with temperature, introducing errors along steep temperature gradients.
  - **Modern balance:** Correlated-$k$ is the standard for global climate models (GCMs) and fast grid forward models, while GPU-accelerated LBL cross-sections are increasingly used for high-resolution cross-correlation spectroscopy ($R \sim 100{,}000$).

# Rayleigh Scattering by Gas Molecules

When the scattering particle radius is much smaller than the wavelength of light ($r \ll \lambda$, i.e. size parameter $x = 2\pi r/\lambda \ll 1$, as for gas atoms and molecules at UV, visible, and IR wavelengths), scattering is in the **Rayleigh regime**:

- **Physical mechanism — induced oscillating dipole:**
  - The oscillating electric field $E(t) = E_0 \cos(2\pi\nu t)$ of the incident light wave polarizes the electron cloud of a gas molecule, inducing an oscillating dipole moment $p(t) = \alpha_p E(t)$, where $\alpha_p$ is the **molecular polarizability**.
  - By classical electrodynamics, an oscillating dipole radiates scattered electromagnetic power proportional to $\ddot{p}^2 \propto \nu^4 \propto \lambda^{-4}$:

$$\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray}}(\lambda) = \frac{128\pi^5}{3\lambda^4}\,\alpha_p^2 \simeq \frac{8\pi^3}{3\lambda^4}\,\frac{(m^2-1)^2}{n^2}\,F_{\mathrm{K}} \propto \lambda^{-4}, \qquad \alpha_p = \frac{3}{4\pi n}\,\frac{m^2-1}{m^2+2}$$

    where $m(\lambda)$ is the real refractive index of the gas at number density $n$, and $F_{\mathrm{K}} \approx 1$ is the King depolarization factor (accounting for non-spherical molecular anisotropy).

- **Role in planetary and exoplanetary atmospheres:**
  - Because of its steep $\lambda^{-4}$ dependence, Rayleigh scattering by $H_2$, He, $N_2$, $CO_2$, and sub-micron hazes dominates short-wavelength continuum opacity in clear atmospheres — producing Earth's blue sky, high UV/blue geometric albedos, and the characteristic $\lambda^{-4}$ optical slope in exoplanet transmission spectra.

# Rayleigh Scattering Cross Section: Earth's Standard Air

In planetary atmospheric modeling, high-precision empirical polynomial fits replace the idealized dipole approximation. For Earth's standard air, the widely adopted formulation by **Bates (1984)** provides the cross section across UV and optical wavelengths:

- **Empirical cross-section formula** ($0.205 < \lambda < 1.05\,\mu$m)**:**

$$\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray,air}}(\lambda) = 10^{-28}\,\lambda^{-4} \sum_{i=0}^{3} a_i\,\lambda^{-2i} \quad [\mathrm{cm}^2/\mathrm{molecule}]$$

  where wavelength $\lambda$ is in $\mu$**m**, with coefficients:

$$a_0 = 3.9729066, \quad a_1 = 4.6547659 \times 10^{-2},$$
$$a_2 = 4.5055995 \times 10^{-4}, \quad a_3 = 2.3229848 \times 10^{-5}$$

- **Physical context and characteristics:**
  - Fits dry standard air (78.084% $N_2$, 20.946% $O_2$, 0.934% Ar, 0.033% $CO_2$) with accuracy better than 0.3%.
  - The $\lambda^{-4}$ factor dominates across visible wavelengths, while higher-order $\lambda^{-6}, \lambda^{-8}, \lambda^{-10}$ terms account for refractive index dispersion $(m^2-1)^2$ and the wavelength-dependent King depolarization factor $F_{\mathrm{K}}(\lambda)$.
  - At $\lambda = 0.5\,\mu$m, $\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray,air}} \approx 6.4 \times 10^{-27}$ cm$^2$/molecule.

**Reference:** Bates, D. R. 1984, Rayleigh Scattering by Air, *Planet. Space Sci.*, **32**, 785–790.

# Rayleigh Scattering Cross Section: Molecular Hydrogen ($H_2$)

For hydrogen-dominated atmospheres (gas giants, mini-Neptunes, and hot Jupiters), the standard analytical dispersion formula is given by **Dalgarno & Williams (1962)**:

- **Analytical dispersion formula for $H_2$:**

$$\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray,H_2}}(\lambda) = \left( \frac{8.14 \times 10^{-13}}{\lambda^4} + \frac{1.28 \times 10^{-6}}{\lambda^6} + \frac{1.61}{\lambda^8} \right) \quad [\mathrm{cm^2/molecule}]$$

  where wavelength $\lambda$ is in **Å** ($1\,\text{Å} = 10^{-4}\,\mu\text{m} = 10^{-8}\,\text{cm}$).

  - *Note on units:* Evaluating this analytical formula with wavelength $\lambda$ in Å yields the scattering cross section directly in $\mathrm{cm^2/molecule}$.

- **Dispersion terms and exoplanetary implications:**
  - The $\lambda^{-6}$ and $\lambda^{-8}$ dispersion terms arise from quantum polarizability approaching the far-UV Lyman-band electronic transitions.
  - At $\lambda = 5000\,\text{Å}$ ($0.5\,\mu\text{m}$), $\sigma_{\mathrm{Ray,H_2}} \approx 1.3 \times 10^{-27}$ $\mathrm{cm^2/molecule}$ — roughly **5 times smaller** than air due to the low polarizability of the compact $H_2$ molecule.
  - In clear hot Jupiter atmospheres, this steep $\lambda^{-4}$ slope sets the short-wavelength continuum probe depth ($P \sim 1$–$10$ bar in visible/UV) in transmission spectra.

**Reference:** Dalgarno, A. & Williams, D. A. 1962, Rayleigh Scattering by Molecular Hydrogen, *ApJ*, **136**, 690–692.

# Condensate Opacities: Nature and Physical Characteristics

Beyond molecular gas absorption and Rayleigh scattering, planetary atmospheres contain liquid droplets and solid particles (**condensate clouds** and **photochemical hazes**):

- **Macroscopic aggregates vs. isolated gas molecules:**
  - Gas molecules possess discrete quantum states (electronic, vibrational, and rotational transitions).
  - Condensates are macroscopic molecular aggregates ($10^6$–$10^{15}$ atoms/molecules). Intermolecular bonding suppresses free rotation and blends vibrational modes, producing **smooth absorption and scattering continua** without discrete spectral lines.
- **Ubiquity and composition across atmospheres:**
  - *Solar System:* Liquid $H_2O$ and water ice (Earth), $H_2SO_4$ droplets (Venus), $NH_3$ and $NH_4SH$ (Jupiter), hydrocarbon hazes (Titan).
  - *Exoplanets:* High-temperature refractory minerals (silicates such as $MgSiO_3$, metal oxides $Al_2O_3$, $TiO_2$, and liquid/solid Fe) as well as photochemical soot/tholins.
- **Fundamental governing optical quantities:**
  - **Size parameter** $x \equiv 2\pi r/\lambda$: ratio of particle circumference to wavelength, dictating whether scattering is Rayleigh ($x \ll 1$), resonant Mie ($x \sim 1$), or geometric optics ($x \gg 1$).
  - **Complex refractive index** $m = n_r + i n_i$: real part $n_r$ governs phase speed, refraction, and scattering; imaginary part $n_i$ governs material absorption.

# Condensate Opacities: Single-Scattering Phase Functions

When a photon is scattered by a gas molecule or cloud particle, its directional probability distribution as a function of the **scattering deflection angle** $\Theta$ ($\cos\Theta = \hat{\mathbf{n}}_{\rm inc} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{n}}_{\rm scat}$) is given by the **single-scattering phase function** $P(\Theta)$:

$$\frac{1}{4\pi}\int_{4\pi} P(\Theta)\,\mathrm{d}\Omega = \frac{1}{2}\int_{-1}^{1} P(\cos\Theta)\,\mathrm{d}(\cos\Theta) = 1,$$

$$g \equiv \langle\cos\Theta\rangle = \frac{1}{4\pi}\int_{4\pi} \cos\Theta\, P(\Theta)\,\mathrm{d}\Omega \in [-1,1]$$

- **Physical meaning of the asymmetry factor $g \equiv \langle\cos\Theta\rangle$:**
  - $g = +1$: pure forward scattering ($\Theta = 0^\circ$); $g = 0$: isotropic or forward–backward symmetric scattering; $g = -1$: pure backscattering ($\Theta = 180^\circ$).
- **Standard analytical phase functions used in radiative transfer:**

$$P_{\rm iso}(\Theta) = 1 \;\; (g = 0), \qquad P_{\rm Ray}(\Theta) = \frac{3}{4}\left(1 + \cos^2\Theta\right) \;\; (g = 0),$$

$$P_{\rm HG}(\Theta) = \frac{1 - g^2}{\left(1 + g^2 - 2g\cos\Theta\right)^{3/2}}$$

  - The empirical one-parameter **Henyey–Greenstein phase function** $P_{\rm HG}(\Theta)$ has $\langle\cos\Theta\rangle = g$ by construction and smoothly interpolates between backward ($g < 0$), isotropic ($g = 0$), and strongly forward-peaked ($g > 0$) cloud scattering.

# Condensate Opacities: Geometric Optics Regime

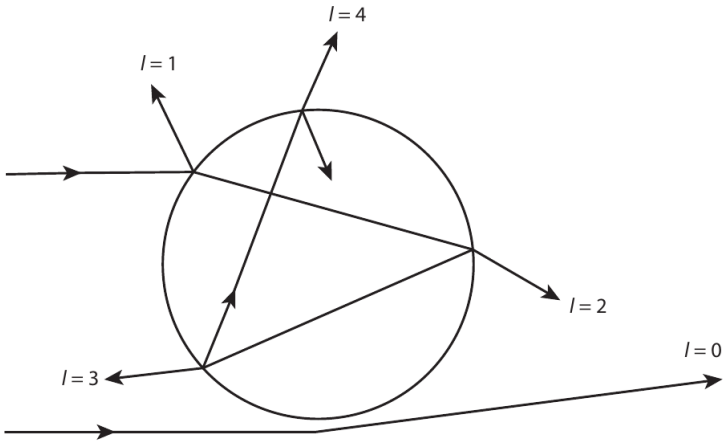



Figure 6: Geometric optics ray paths through a spherical droplet: diffraction ($l = 0$), external reflection ($l = 1$), double refraction ($l = 2$), one internal reflection ($l = 3$, primary rainbow), and two internal reflections ($l = 4$, secondary rainbow). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.12.

- **Why condensate opacities are smooth continua:** Liquid droplets and solid cloud/haze grains (e.g. $H_2O$, $NH_3$, $H_2SO_4$, $MgSiO_3$, Fe, $Al_2O_3$) are macroscopic aggregates in which intermolecular forces lock out free rotation, blending transitions into continuous bands governed by the **size parameter** and **complex refractive index**:

$$\boxed{x \equiv \frac{2\pi r}{\lambda}, \qquad m = n_r + i n_i}$$

($n_r$: phase speed / refraction; $n_i$: damping / absorption).

- **Geometric optics ray tracing ($x \gg 1$, $r \gg \lambda$):**
  - Light rays undergo **diffraction** around the sphere ($l = 0$, forward peak at $\Theta = 0^\circ$ of area $\pi r^2$), **external reflection** ($l = 1$), **two-surface refraction** ($l = 2$), and **internal reflections** ($l \geq 3$).
  - Because both intercepted rays ($\pi r^2$) and diffracted rays ($\pi r^2$) are removed from the beam, a large sphere extinguishes **twice** its geometric area ($\sigma_{\rm ext} \to 2\pi r^2$, $\boxed{Q_{\rm ext} \to 2}$: the **extinction paradox**).

# Droplet Phase Function: Rainbows, Glory, and Mie vs. Geometric Optics

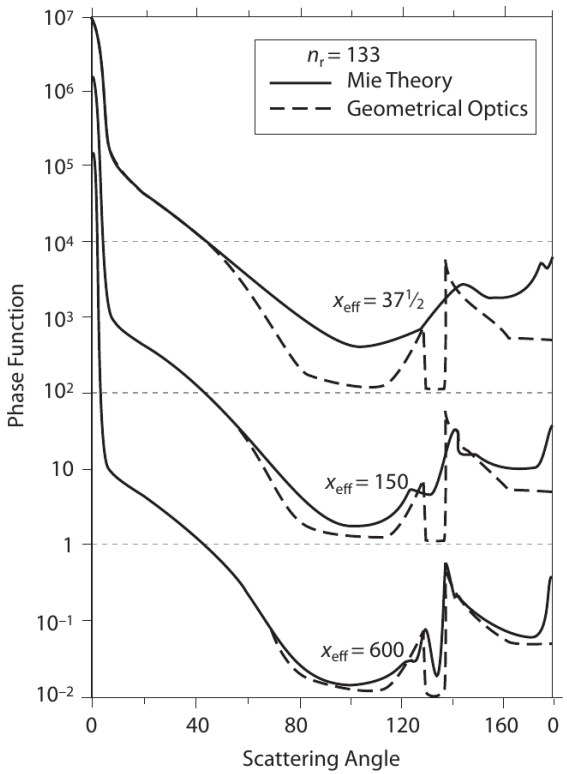



Figure 7: Single-scattering phase function $P(\Theta)$ of water droplets ($x \sim 250$–$500$): exact Mie theory vs. geometric optics. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.13.

- **Comparing Mie theory and geometric optics for large droplets ($x \gg 1$, Fig. 8.13):**
  - **Forward diffraction peak ($\Theta \simeq 0^\circ$):** Diffraction ($l = 0$) and grazing transmission ($l = 2$) produce an intense forward-scattering spike spanning several orders of magnitude in $P(\Theta)$.
  - **Primary and secondary rainbows ($\Theta \simeq 137^\circ$ and $130^\circ$):** For spherical liquid water droplets ($n_r \simeq 1.33$), rays undergoing one internal reflection ($l = 3$) cluster at a minimum deviation angle of $\Theta \simeq 137^\circ$ (**primary rainbow**), while two internal reflections ($l = 4$) cluster at $\Theta \simeq 130^\circ$ (**secondary rainbow**), with **Alexander's dark band** between them.
  - **The Glory ($\Theta \simeq 180^\circ$):** Near exact backscattering ($\Theta \simeq 180^\circ$), surface waves and internally reflected rays interfere constructively to create a sharp backscattering peak called the **glory** — captured by **Mie theory** (solid curve) but missed by geometric optics (dotted curve).
- **Remote-sensing diagnostic:** Rainbow and glory angles in planetary phase curves and polarimetry uniquely identify the refractive index $n_r$ and spherical droplet shape of clouds (e.g. $H_2SO_4$ clouds on Venus).

# The Atmospheric Glory: Physical Mechanism and Observation

The **glory** (광환, 光環) is a wave-optical phenomenon of concentric colored rings centered on the **antisolar point** ($\Theta \approx 180^\circ$), appearing around an observer's shadow on uniform cloud droplets:

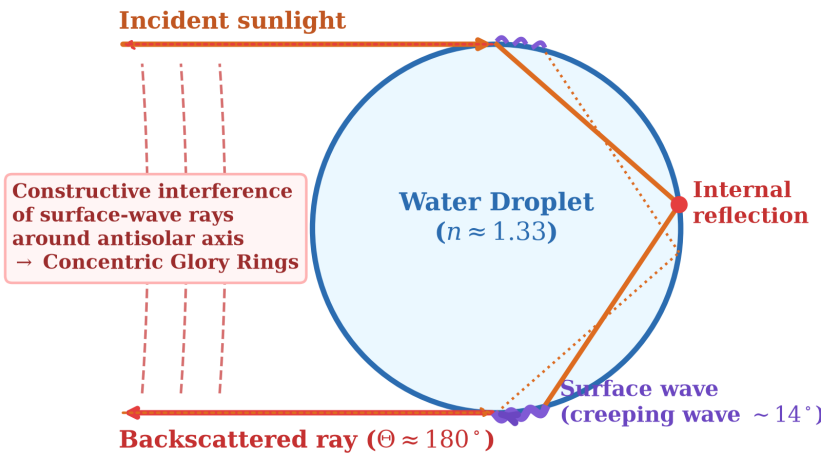



Figure 8: **Formation mechanism:** Surface creeping waves ($\sim 14^\circ$) bridge the geometric gap to $180^\circ$ backscatter.



Figure 9: **Observed glory:** Brocken spectre on mountain clouds, showing concentric interference rings around the antisolar axis.

- **Geometric limit vs. wave optics:** In water ($n \approx 1.33$), one internal reflection deflects grazing rays to at most $\Theta \approx 166^\circ$. Edge rays excite **surface creeping waves** along the droplet perimeter that shed into exact backscatter ($\Theta = 180^\circ$, Nussenzveig 1977).
- **Interference & exoplanet diagnostic:** Rays tunneling around opposite azimuths interfere to form concentric rings. A glory requires spherical droplets with uniform radii (observed on Earth and Venus, and recently inferred on WASP-76b).

# Mie Theory: Exact Solution for Homogeneous Spheres

For spherical particles of any radius $r$ (especially $x = 2\pi r/\lambda \sim 1$, where neither Rayleigh scattering nor geometric optics applies), **Mie theory** gives the exact analytical multipole solution of Maxwell's equations inside and outside a homogeneous sphere of complex refractive index $m = n_r + i n_i$:

$$Q_{\text{scat}} \equiv \frac{\sigma_{\text{scat}}}{\pi r^2} = \frac{2}{x^2}\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}(2n+1)\left(|a_n|^2 + |b_n|^2\right), \qquad Q_{\text{ext}} \equiv \frac{\sigma_{\text{ext}}}{\pi r^2} = \frac{2}{x^2}\sum_{n=1}^{\infty}(2n+1)\,\text{Re}\left(a_n + b_n\right)$$

- **Absorption efficiency and cross section:** $Q_{\text{abs}} = Q_{\text{ext}} - Q_{\text{scat}} \quad \left(\sigma_{\text{abs}} = \sigma_{\text{ext}} - \sigma_{\text{scat}}\right)$.
- **Electric ($a_n$) and magnetic ($b_n$) multipole Mie coefficients:** Expressed in terms of the Riccati–Bessel functions $\psi_n(z) \equiv z\, j_n(z)$ and $\zeta_n(z) \equiv z\,[j_n(z) + i\, y_n(z)]$ of argument $x$ and $mx$:

$$a_n = \frac{\psi_n'(mx)\psi_n(x) - m\psi_n(mx)\psi_n'(x)}{\psi_n'(mx)\zeta_n(x) - m\psi_n(mx)\zeta_n'(x)}, \qquad b_n = \frac{m\psi_n'(mx)\psi_n(x) - \psi_n(mx)\psi_n'(x)}{m\psi_n'(mx)\zeta_n(x) - \psi_n(mx)\zeta_n'(x)}$$

  - The infinite series converges rapidly after $n_{\max} \approx x + 4x^{1/3} + 2$ terms.
  - In the small-particle limit ($x \ll 1$), the $n = 1$ electric dipole term $a_1$ dominates and reproduces **Rayleigh scattering** ($Q_{\text{scat}} \propto x^4 \propto \lambda^{-4}$); in the large-particle limit ($x \gg 1$), it approaches **geometric optics** ($Q_{\text{ext}} \to 2$).

# Mie Scattering Efficiency: Role of Absorption and Size Distribution

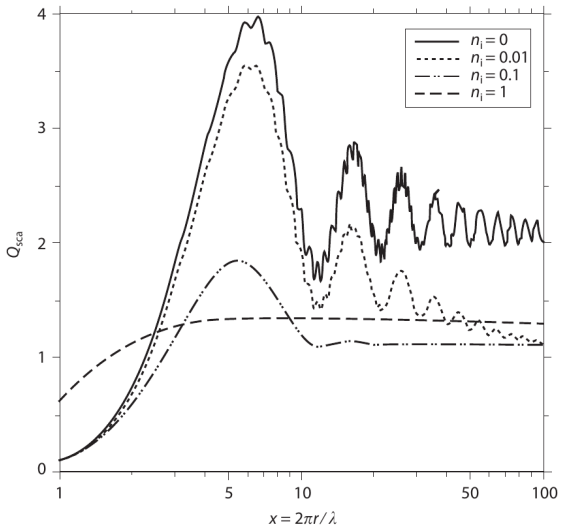



Figure 10: $Q_{\text{scat}}(x)$ for single spheres with $n_r = 1.33$ and $n_i = 0, 0.01, 0.1, 1$. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.14.

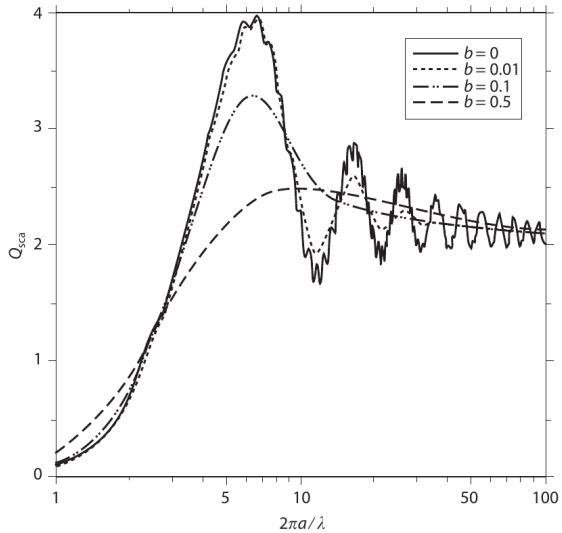



Figure 11: $Q_{\text{scat}}(x)$ integrated over a size distribution of variance $b$. Seager (2010), Fig. 8.15.

- **Interference ripples (Fig. 8.14):** For non-absorbing single spheres ($n_i = 0$), interference between diffracted ($l = 0$) and transmitted ($l = 2$) rays produces large oscillations in $Q_{\text{scat}}(x)$ around the asymptotic limit $Q_{\text{scat}} \to 2$.
- **Damping by absorption ($n_i > 0$):** When $n_i \gtrsim 0.01$, transmitted rays are absorbed inside the sphere, damping out the interference peaks and reducing the large-$x$ limit to $Q_{\text{scat}} \to 1$ (with $Q_{\text{abs}} \to 1$, so $Q_{\text{ext}} \to 2$).
- **Averaging over a size distribution $n(r)$ (Fig. 8.15):**

$$\bar{\sigma}_{\text{scat,ext}} = \frac{\int_0^\infty \sigma_{\text{scat,ext}}(r)\, n(r)\, \mathrm{d}r}{\int_0^\infty n(r)\, \mathrm{d}r}\,.$$

Realistic cloud size dispersion ($b \gtrsim 0.1$) washes out single-sphere ripples into a smooth curve.

# Optical Properties of Exoplanet Cloud Condensates

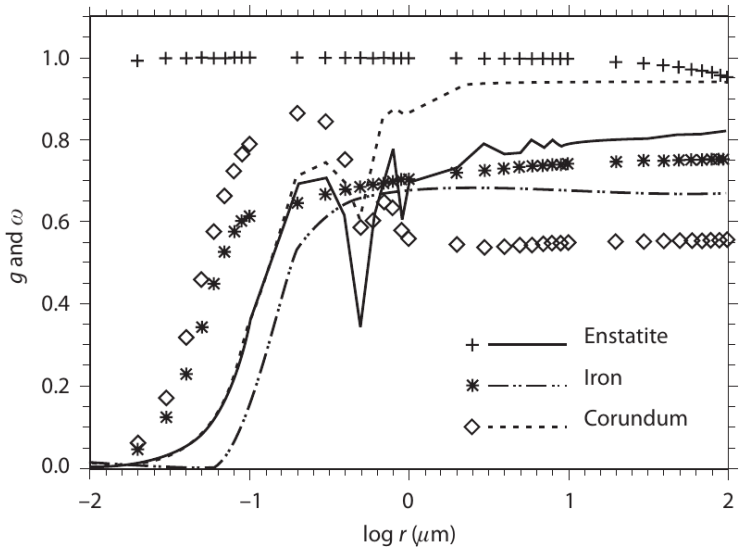



Figure 12: Asymmetry factor $g(\lambda)$ and single-scattering albedo $\omega_0(\lambda)$ for $MgSiO_3$, Fe, and $Al_2O_3$ clouds ($\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.16.

- **High-temperature exoplanet condensates ($T \sim 1200$–$2000$ K, Fig. 8.16):** In hot Jupiters and brown dwarfs, refractory elements condense into mineral and metal clouds with dramatically different single-scattering albedo $\omega_0 = \bar{\sigma}_{\rm scat}/\bar{\sigma}_{\rm ext}$ and asymmetry factor $g$ (shown for $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m):
  - **Enstatite ($MgSiO_3$, silicate, $n_i \ll 1$):** nearly pure dielectric scatterer in the optical and near-IR with $\omega_0 \approx 1$ (bright, highly reflective clouds) and strong forward scattering ($g \approx 0.6$–$0.8$).
  - **Corundum ($Al_2O_3$, refractory oxide):** condenses at the highest temperatures ($T \sim 1800$ K), moderately absorbing with intermediate $\omega_0 \approx 0.6$–$0.8$.
  - **Solid/liquid Iron (Fe, metal, $n_i \sim 1$):** strongly absorbing across all wavelengths with low $\omega_0 \approx 0.5$–$0.6$ (dark, low-albedo clouds that efficiently absorb starlight and heat the atmosphere).
- **Drop-off at long wavelengths ($\lambda \gg 2\pi\bar{r}$, $x \ll 1$):** For $\lambda \gtrsim 3$–$5\,\mu$m, $x$ enters the Rayleigh regime ($Q_{\rm scat} \propto \lambda^{-4} \ll Q_{\rm abs} \propto \lambda^{-1}$), causing both $g$ and $\omega_0$ to drop toward zero.

# Structure of Silicate Cloud Condensates

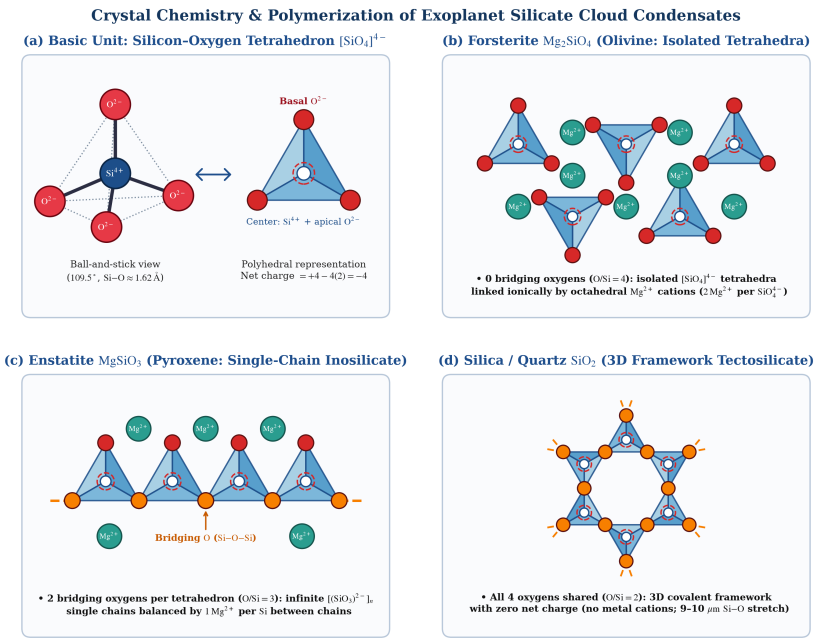



Figure 13: Polymerization of $[SiO_4]^{4-}$ tetrahedra from isolated olivine ($Mg_2SiO_4$) to single-chain enstatite ($MgSiO_3$) and 3D framework silica ($SiO_2$).

- **Basic unit — $[SiO_4]^{4-}$ tetrahedron:** A central $Si^{4+}$ ion is bonded to four $O^{2-}$ ions (109.5°). Silicate minerals are classified by the number of shared corner **bridging oxygens** (Si–O–Si) per tetrahedron:
  - **Forsterite ($Mg_2SiO_4$, olivine / nesosilicate, O/Si $= 4$): 0 bridging oxygens**; isolated $[SiO_4]^{4-}$ units linked by $Mg^{2+}$ ions ($T_{cond} \sim 1500$–$1700$ K).
  - **Enstatite ($MgSiO_3$, pyroxene / inosilicate, O/Si $= 3$): 2 bridging oxygens** per tetrahedron form infinite $[(SiO_3)^{2-}]_n$ single chains balanced by $Mg^{2+}$ ($T_{cond} \sim 1300$–$1500$ K).
  - **Quartz / Silica ($SiO_2$, tectosilicate, O/Si $= 2$): All 4 oxygens shared** in a neutral 3D covalent network.
- **Mid-infrared vibrational bands ($\lambda \sim 8$–$20\,\mu$m):** Transparent in the optical ($\omega_0 \approx 1$), but Si–O stretching (9–11 $\mu$m) and O–Si–O bending (16–20 $\mu$m) modes produce strong mid-IR absorption features (*JWST*/MIRI).

# Scattering Phase Functions of Exoplanet Mineral and Metal Clouds

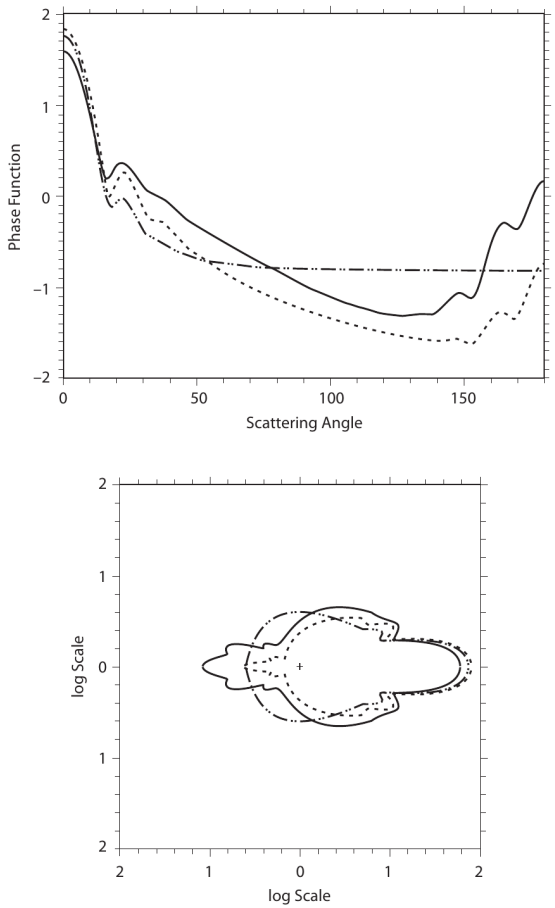



Figure 14: Phase functions $P(\Theta)$ and polar scattering diagrams at $\lambda = 500$ nm for $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m condensate clouds ($MgSiO_3$, Fe, $Al_2O_3$). Seager (2010), Fig. 8.17.

- **Directional scattering at $\lambda = 500$ nm, $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m ($x = 2\pi\bar{r}/\lambda \simeq 12.6$, Fig. 8.17):**
  - Because $\bar{r} = 1\,\mu$m is larger than $\lambda = 0.5\,\mu$m ($x \gg 1$), all three condensates exhibit an **intense forward-scattering diffraction peak** near $\Theta = 0^\circ$ (spanning more than two orders of magnitude in $P(\Theta)$).
  - **Translucent dielectric grains ($MgSiO_3$, solid; $Al_2O_3$, dashed):** Internal refraction and reflection survive inside low-$n_i$ dielectric particles, producing enhanced side- and back-scattering lobes near $\Theta \sim 140^\circ$–$180^\circ$.
  - **Opaque metallic droplets (Fe, dash-dotted):** Because $n_i \sim 1$, refracted rays are absorbed inside the iron droplet before exiting; scattering is limited to diffraction ($l = 0$) and external reflection ($l = 1$), giving much weaker backscattering.
- **Impact on exoplanet transit spectra:** When $x = 2\pi r/\lambda \gtrsim 1$, cloud extinction is nearly independent of wavelength (**gray opacity**), raising the continuum photosphere to high altitudes and **muting or flattening molecular absorption features**.

# Continuum Opacities in Planetary Atmospheres

In spectral windows between strong molecular bands — or in hot/dense atmospheres — smooth **continuum opacities** control the depth from which photons escape:

- **1. Collision-Induced Absorption (CIA; $H_2$–$H_2$, $H_2$–He, $N_2$–$N_2$, $CO_2$–$CO_2$):**
  - Close binary collisions briefly distort symmetric electron clouds ($\Delta t \sim 10^{-13}$ s), inducing a transient dipole moment that absorbs infrared photons across broad roto-translational and ro-vibrational continua ($\Delta\tilde{\nu} \sim 1/[2\pi c\Delta t] \sim 50$–$500\ \mathrm{cm}^{-1}$).
  - Because CIA is a two-body process ($\alpha_{\mathrm{CIA}} \propto n_1 n_2 \propto P^2$), it dominates the deep infrared opacity of $H_2$–He gas giants, brown dwarfs, cool white dwarfs, and dense $N_2$/$CO_2$ atmospheres (Titan, Venus), forcing deep atmospheres to be convective.
- **2. Bound-free (photoionization and photodissociation) absorption:**
  - A photon with energy $h\nu$ exceeding the ionization threshold $\chi_n$ of an atom/ion (or dissociation energy $D_0$ of a molecule) liberates a free electron (or dissociates the bond), producing continuous absorption at all frequencies $\nu \geq \chi_n/h$ (e.g. H, $H^-$, $O_2$, $O_3$, $H_2O$ UV continua).
- **3. Free-free (bremsstrahlung / inverse bremsstrahlung) absorption:**
  - A free thermal electron passing near an ion or neutral atom/molecule (H, $H_2$, He) absorbs a photon to jump between two unbound continuum kinetic energy states ($\alpha_{\mathrm{ff}} \propto n_e n_{\mathrm{ion}} \nu^{-3}$).
- **4. Negative hydrogen ion ($H^-$) bound-free and free-free opacity:**
  - In ultra-hot Jupiters ($T \gtrsim 2200$ K) and cool stars, thermal ionization of alkali metals supplies free electrons that bind weakly to neutral H atoms ($H^-$ binding energy 0.754 eV, threshold $\lambda \leq 1.64\,\mu$m), making $H^-$ bound-free ($< 1.64\,\mu$m) and free-free ($> 1.64\,\mu$m) the dominant optical/near-IR continuum opacity.

# Summary: Opacities

- **Atomic & molecular energy hierarchy:** Under the Born–Oppenheimer approximation,
  $E_{\text{total}} \simeq E_{\text{el}} + E_{\text{vib}} + E_{\text{rot}}$ with
  $\Delta E_{\text{el}}$ (UV/vis, few eV) $\gg \Delta E_{\text{vib}}$ (near/mid-IR, 0.1 eV) $\gg \Delta E_{\text{rot}}$ (far-IR/microwave, $10^{-3}$ eV).
- **Rotational & vibrational spectra:**
  - **Rigid rotor:** $E_J = BJ(J+1)$ ($B = \hbar^2/[2I]$, $g_J = 2J+1$, $\Delta J = \pm 1$) gives equally spaced lines $\Delta E = 2BJ$.
  - **Simple harmonic oscillator:** $E_\upsilon = (\upsilon + \frac{1}{2})h\nu_0$ ($\nu_0 = \frac{1}{2\pi}\sqrt{C/\mu}$, $\Delta\upsilon = \pm 1$). Combined ro-vibrational transitions split into **P** ($\Delta J = -1$), **Q** ($\Delta J = 0$), and **R** ($\Delta J = +1$) branches across $3N-5$ (linear) or $3N-6$ (nonlinear) normal modes.
- **Line strengths & broadening ($\sigma_{lu}(\tilde{\nu}) = S_{lu}(T)\, f(\tilde{\nu} - \tilde{\nu}_0)$):**
  - **LTE (Boltzmann)** vs. **Non-LTE (statistical equilibrium)** level populations govern $S_{lu}(T)$, scaled from HITRAN/HITEMP/ExoMol via partition functions $Q(T)$.
  - **Doppler broadening** produces a Gaussian core ($\gamma_{\text{D}} = \frac{\nu_0}{c}\sqrt{2k_{\text{B}}T/m}$, low $P$); **collisional broadening** produces Lorentzian wings ($\gamma_{\text{L}} \propto P\,T^{-n_T}$, high $P$); their convolution is the **Voigt profile**, efficiently integrated using the ***k*-distribution method**.
- **Scattering, clouds, & continuum opacities:**
  - **Gas Rayleigh scattering** ($x \ll 1$) scales as $\sigma_{\text{Ray}} \propto \lambda^{-4}$ with $P_{\text{Ray}}(\Theta) = \frac{3}{4}(1+\cos^2\Theta)$.
  - **Condensate clouds/hazes** ($H_2O$, $MgSiO_3$, Fe, $Al_2O_3$) are governed by $x = 2\pi r/\lambda$ and $m = n_r + in_i$, bridged from Rayleigh ($x \ll 1$) through **Mie theory** ($x \sim 1$) to **geometric optics** ($x \gg 1$, $Q_{\text{ext}} \to 2$, gray clouds).
  - **Continuum opacities** (CIA $\propto P^2$, bound-free, free-free, $H^-$) close spectral windows and drive deep convection.